MODULE 16

Job, Survey and SIM Cloning Fraud

Certified Cyber Criminologist - Police / LEA Training

Samir Raja (CYBER07) | Cyber Crime Investigator & Offensive Security Researcher

What You Will Learn

Fraudsters steal jobs, savings and phone numbers. In this module you learn to **chase the timeline and the money**.

- **SIM swap vs SIM cloning** - the criminal's method behind both
- **Minute-by-minute timelines** - and what to ask the telecom nodal officer
- **Fake job red flags** - genuine offer vs trap
- **Victim-phone evidence** - the correct collection procedure
- **WHOIS, ad libraries, payment trails** - finding who is behind a fake scheme

One Morning, No Network

You wake up. Your phone shows **no signal**. Hours later the bank calls: **lakhs withdrawn**. Your OTPs went to someone else's phone. This is SIM swap fraud - and it is happening across India.

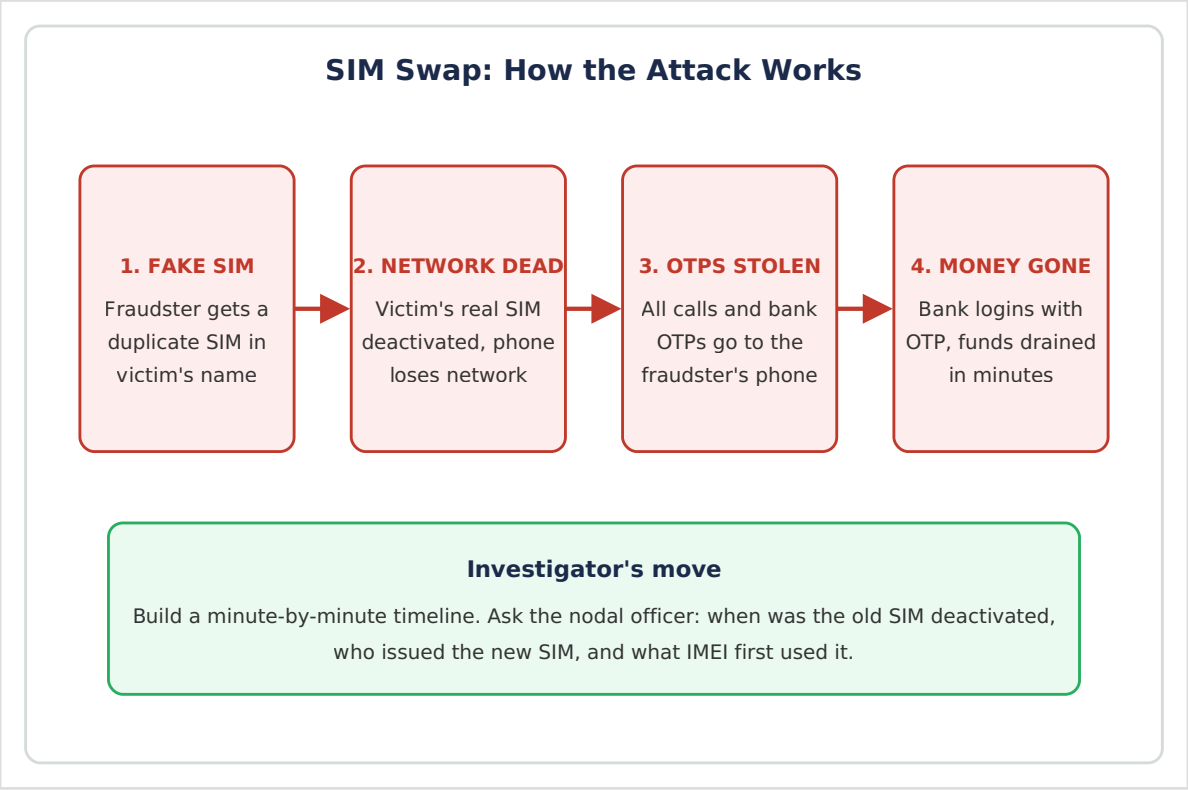
- A fraudster gets a **duplicate SIM in your name** from your telecom company
- Your genuine SIM is deactivated. Calls, SMS and bank OTPs now reach the fraudster
- He logs into your bank, enters the OTP, and drains the account
- The criminal **never touches your phone** - he only needs your personal information

SIM Swap vs SIM Cloning

Same motive, different method. Know the difference - your questions change with it.

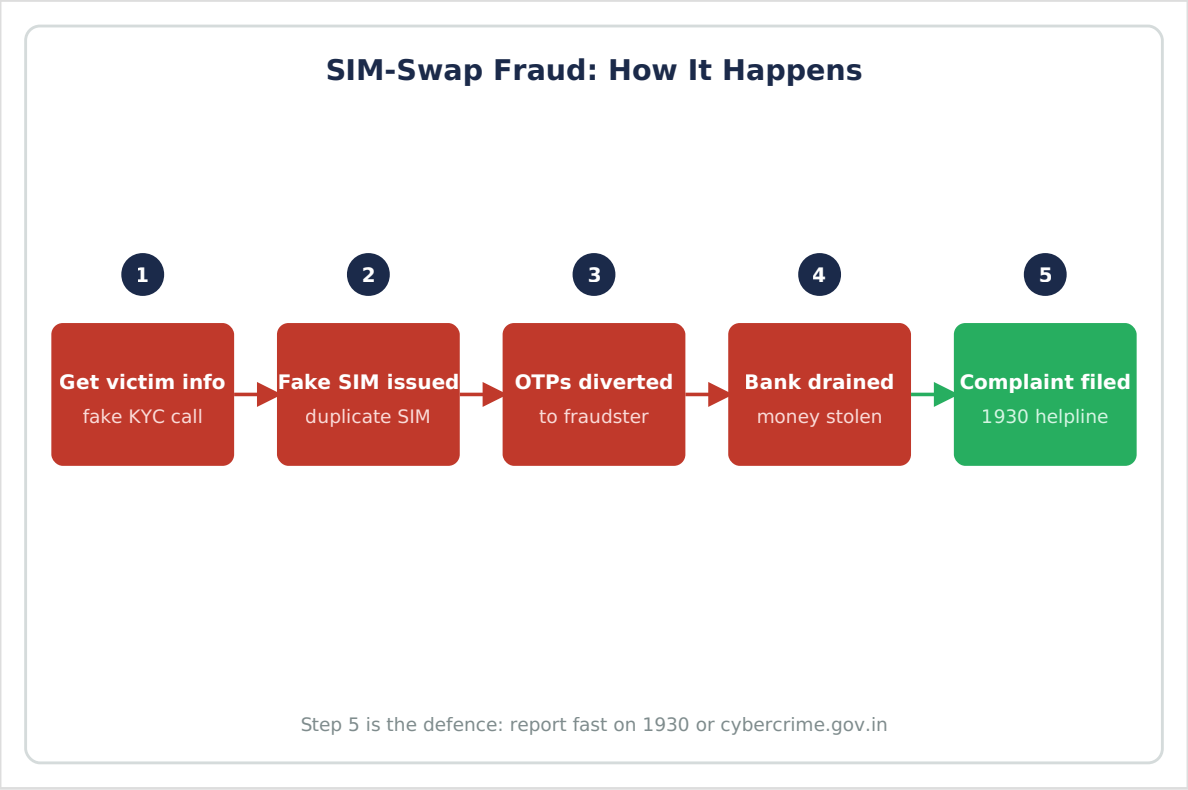
- **SIM swap:** duplicate SIM issued through the telecom company, by fooling an agent with fake documents or stolen personal data
- **SIM cloning:** copying the digital identity of the SIM itself - rarer, more technical
- In both, the biggest weapon is **social engineering** - lying to people and winning their trust
- Key investigation question: **where did the victim share personal information recently** - surveys, portals, leaks

SIM Swap: How the Attack Works



- Four steps, often completed in **under two hours**
- Your counter: a **minute-by-minute timeline** of the same window
- Every step leaves a record - with the telecom company and the bank

The SIM-Swap Timeline



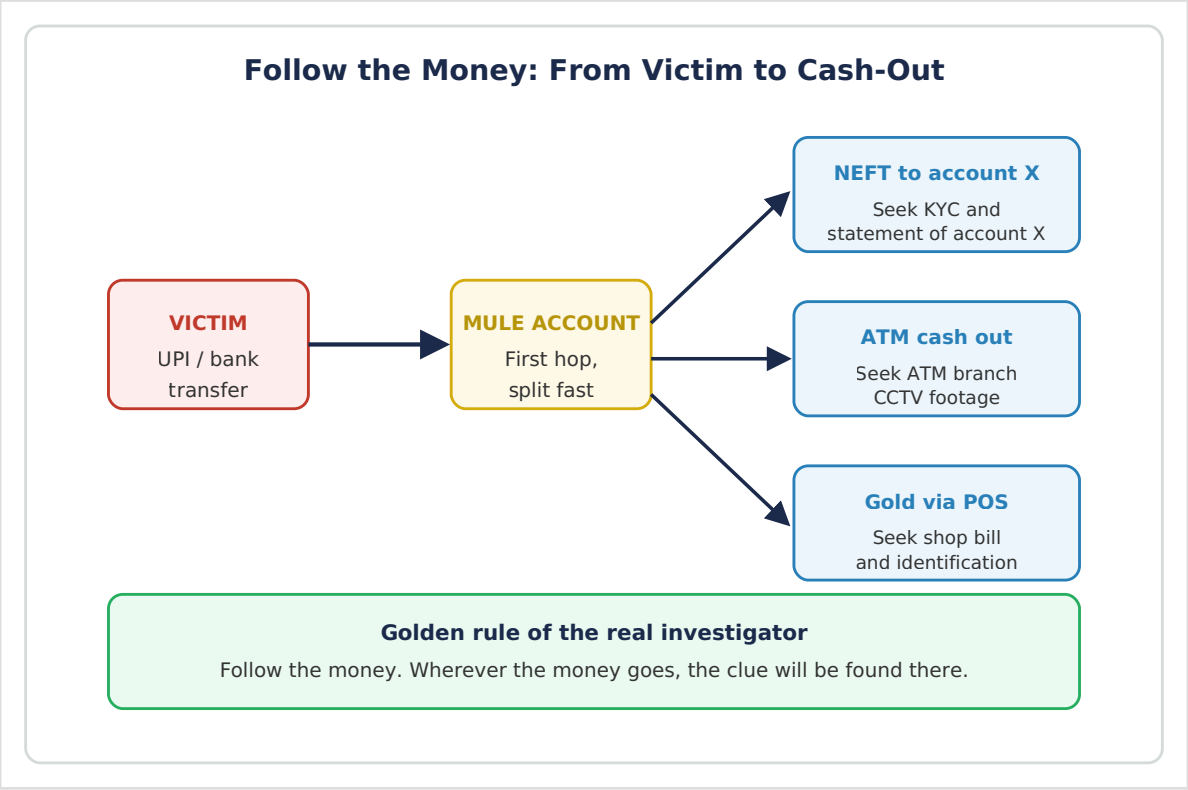
- Sample case: SIM changed 7:40 AM, network lost 8:15, fraud 9:05 to 9:20
- The timeline shows **speed and order** - the criminal's plan in numbers
- It is the **backbone of the whole investigation**

The Nodal Officer: Six Things to Ask

The telecom company's nodal officer is your **most important source** in a SIM swap case. Ask for all six:

- **CAF** - the Customer Acquisition Form of the new SIM, with name, address and documents
- **Shop or agent** - where the new SIM was issued, with name and address
- **IMEI** - which handset first used the new SIM
- **Deactivation record** - when and on whose request the old SIM was killed, plus the tower location of first activation

Follow the Money



- Money moves fast: UPI credits, then split within minutes
- Each hop needs a **legal notice**: NPCI/bank, account X's bank, ATM branch, jewellery shop
- **Follow the money** - wherever it goes, the clue is there

First Response: The Golden Hour

In SIM swap and job fraud, **speed saves money**. Drill this order into every complainant:

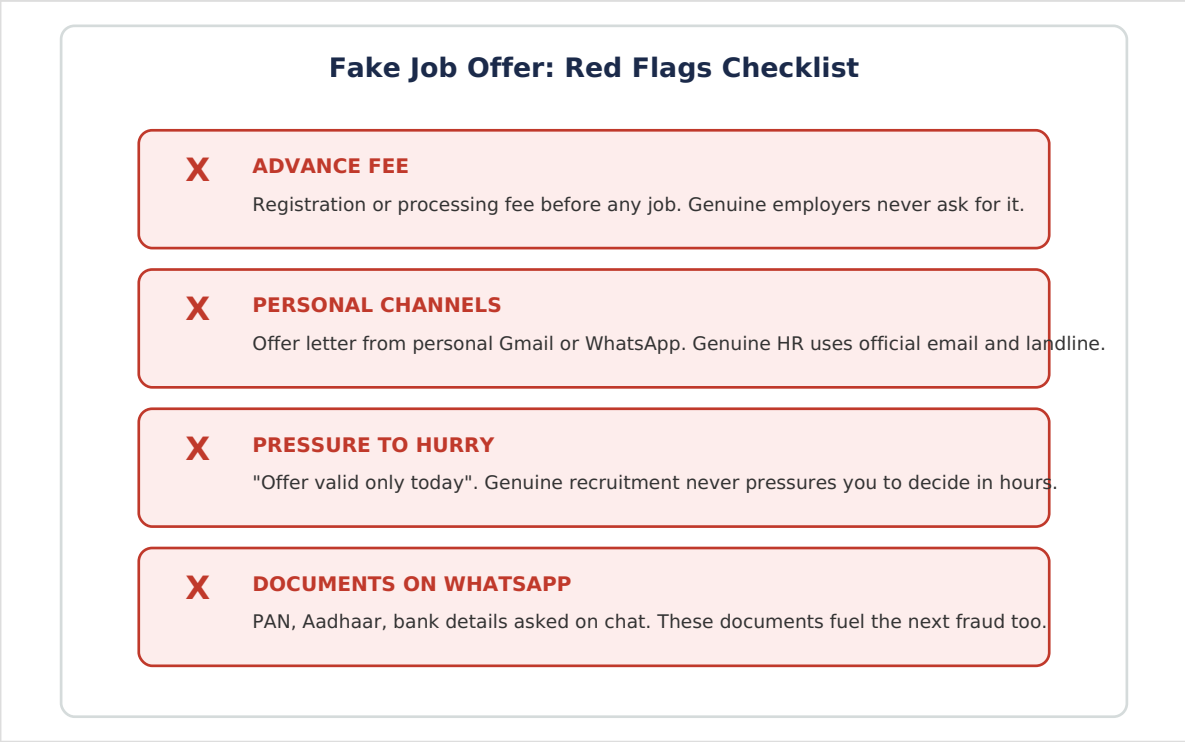
- **Call 1930 immediately** - the helpline can freeze the money trail before it moves further
- File on **cybercrime.gov.in** - creates the written record with a complaint number
- Inform the bank **in writing** - verbal calls get forgotten, letters get actioned
- Then preserve: screenshots, chats, transaction receipts - **before anything gets deleted**

Job Fraud: The Trap

Unemployed youth are the target. The method is industrial: **data, call, fee, vanish**.

- Victim data picked from **online job portals** - then a call from a fake HR of a big company
- **Registration or processing fee** demanded: 3,000, 5,000, 7,000 rupees
- A **fake offer letter** arrives; PAN, Aadhaar and marksheets asked on WhatsApp - documents reused in the next fraud
- Contact continues for days to avoid suspicion - then **all numbers go silent**

Fake Job Offer: Red Flags



- Teach victims this checklist - **three rules never break**
- No genuine company asks for a fee. No genuine HR uses Gmail. No genuine process pressures you
- Ask every victim these three questions - the answers become evidence

Tracing the Fake Call Centre

Behind the HR voice is a **call centre**. Your job: map it like a network.

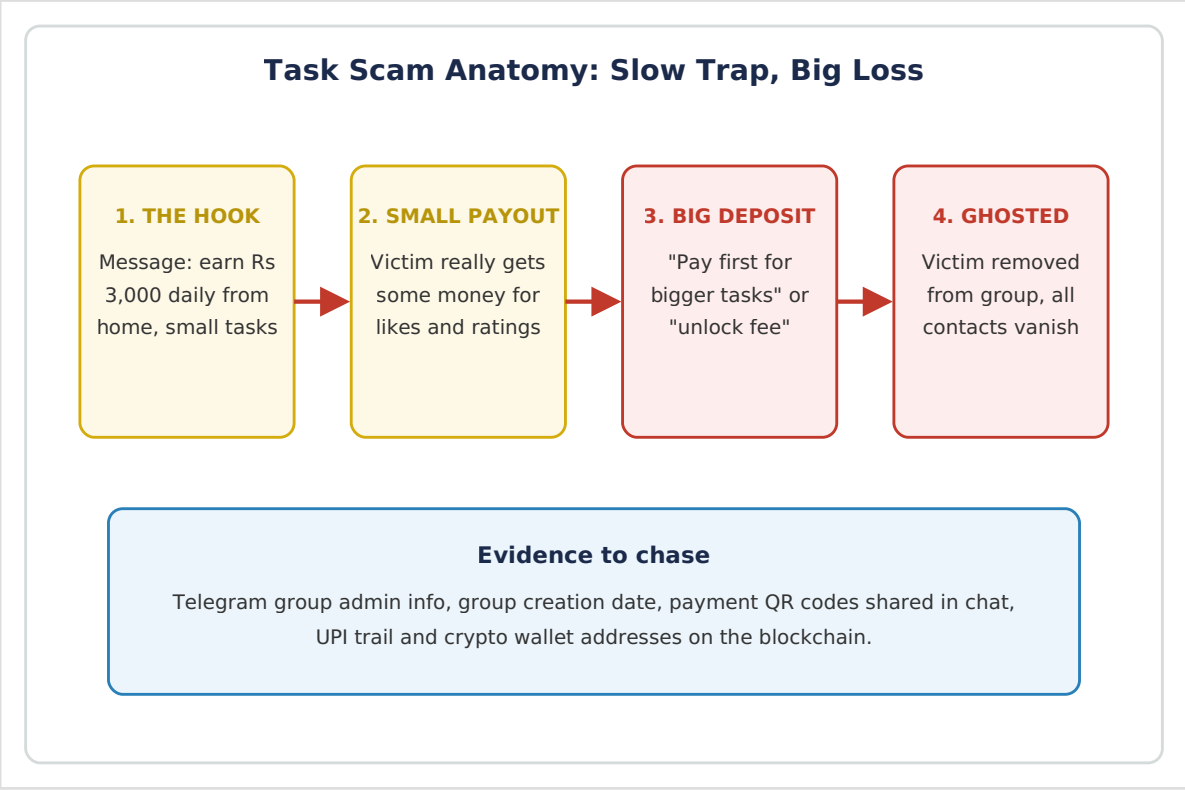
- **Where** did the calls come from - and was **VoIP** (internet calling) software like Xlite used
- **Money path:** which accounts or QR codes received the registration fees
- **Domain:** who registered the fake company's website - WHOIS first, then the registrar
- **Ads:** who paid for the social media advertisements - the payment trail names a person

Work-From-Home Task Scam

The cruellest trap - because it **pays you first**. Small profit builds trust; the big loss follows.

- Message: earn thousands daily from home - just likes, ratings, video views
- Early tasks **really pay** - trust is manufactured, rupee by rupee
- Then: **deposit first for bigger tasks**, or pay an unlock fee - the big amount vanishes, and so does the group
- Often routed through **crypto (USDT)** to hide the trail - but the blockchain still records everything

Task Scam Anatomy



- Four stages: hook, small payout, big deposit, ghosted
- Evidence lives in the **Telegram group**: admin info, creation date, QR codes
- Crypto wallets are traceable - **exchanges respond to legal notices**

Survey, Fake Schemes, Telemarketing

Different costumes, same playbook: **extract information, extract money**.

- **Fake surveys:** name, address, bank details, OTP - sometimes dressed as a prize or a government scheme
- **Bogus schemes:** double money, guaranteed returns - advertisements that look completely genuine
- **Telemarketing fraud:** 'I am from the bank, your card will be blocked' - **fear plus hurry** on a phone call
- Government schemes never take a **verification charge** - that one line unmasks most of them

Chasing the Advertisement Money

Someone **paid** to run that fake ad. Follow the payment and you find a person.

- **WHOIS:** who registered the domain, when, and through which host - free public record
- **Meta Ad Library:** free tool showing who runs Facebook/Instagram ads, since when, in what versions
- **BNSS s.94 notice** to the platform: account name, email, phone, payment card details, full ad log
- Order of work: **open sources first, legal notices second** - then follow the next link

The Fraudster's Four Signs

Veterans recognise the pattern instantly. **Every sign is also evidence** - record each with a date.

- **Hurry:** 'send the money now, the offer ends' - pressure is the criminal's favourite tool
- **Secrecy:** 'do not tell your family' - because one sensible person breaks the trap
- **Money first:** genuine jobs never take fees; genuine banks never ask OTPs; genuine schemes never take verification charges
- **Fake identity:** lookalike websites, WhatsApp documents - when the victim says 'he told me to hurry', that statement itself is evidence

Preserving Evidence: The Victim's Phone

Deleted chats do not come back. A deactivated number is never found again.

Preserve first, ask later.

- **Flight mode immediately** - no remote wipe, no new data overwriting the old
- Screenshot every chat with the criminal - **date and time visible** - plus a full chat export
- Call logs, transaction receipts with **UTR numbers**, list of installed apps with dates
- Tag everything: case number, evidence number, received from whom, collected by whom - the **chain of custody** starts here

Victim-Phone Evidence Checklist



- Five green checks: calls, SMS/OTPs, apps, screenshots, bank alerts
- Date and time on **every** item - undated evidence is weak evidence
- The phone is private property: taken only under **legal authority**

Questioning the Victim: Order and Respect

The victim is scared and ashamed. **Calm questions get complete answers**; scolding gets silence.

- Always **chronological**: first contact (call/SMS/WhatsApp/ad), what was said, what was shared, money route, SIM/phone changes, what the victim did so far
- Ask about **pressure**: 'were you told to hurry, told not to tell anyone' - the answers document the method
- Write the statement **then and there**, get it signed, date and time on it
- Contradictions? Clarify **politely, immediately** - not later

Mistakes That Weaken the Case

Good investigators avoid these five traps:

- Building the timeline from the **statement alone** - always match against bank and telecom records
- **Calling the suspect numbers** yourself to 'investigate' - you warn the gang
- Delaying the **1930 call** - 'we will see tomorrow' lets the money vanish
- Browsing the victim's **private photos and chats** beyond the case scope - illegal and unethical
- Forgetting the **hash value** - without it, digital evidence is just a file

Real Case: 26 Lakh SIM Swap on a Travel Company

Mumbai, Goregaon. A company's bank-linked number **suddenly went dead**.

- The accountant was told a new SIM needed an email request - the SIM never came, but **26 lakh in fake transfers** did
- FIR at the North Cyber Police. The money trail was chased - **three arrested from Jalandhar**
- The **1930 helpline blocked a large part** of the amount; the rest went to cash and gold
- Source The Times of India
- Lessons: telecom records revealed the swap; bank records led to the accused; **early complaint saved lakhs**

Real Case: Fake Job Call Centres, Delhi - 11 Arrested

October 2026. Two fake placement centres ran from the Lal Ratan Building near Shadipur Metro.

- Job-seeker data lifted from portals like Shine.com; fake HR calls; **1,200 to 3,500 rupees** as registration fees
- One centre used **Xlite VoIP software** - no authorisation letter, no placement agreement, no genuine candidate on record
- **Technical call-pattern analysis** exposed the heavy volume of job calls from the location
- Source NDTV
- Lessons: VoIP and call patterns unmask the centre; the **money path maps the network**

Your Turn: Labs in This Module

Five hands-on labs in Chapter 16 - all on **sample data**, marked as such:

- **Lab 1:** Build a minute-by-minute SIM-swap timeline and draft the nodal-officer request list
- **Lab 2:** Spot the fake among five job messages - underline every red flag
- **Lab 3:** The victim-phone evidence checklist, with date-time on every item
- **Lab 4:** WHOIS plus ad-library desk work on a fictional fake-scheme site
- **Lab 5:** Extract the money trail from a sample bank statement - find the cash-out point

Key Takeaways

If you remember nothing else from Module 16:

- SIM swap needs **no access to the phone** - only the victim's personal data
- The **timeline is the backbone** - build it minute by minute, verify against records
- The nodal officer's six answers **name the fraudster's SIM**
- **Follow the money** - UPI to mule to ATM or gold, with a notice at every hop
- Genuine jobs never take fees; genuine banks never ask OTPs
- **1930 first, evidence second, questions third** - in that order

Review Questions

- 1. A victim's network died at 8 AM; fraud hit at 9 AM. List the six things you ask the nodal officer, and what each one proves.
- 2. Why does a task scam pay the victim real money at first? What is the criminal buying with those small payouts?
- 3. You find a fake job site. Write the four-step desk plan - open sources first, legal notices second.
- 4. A victim's phone arrives at the station. What are your first three actions, and why in that order?
- 5. Convert the four fraudster signs (hurry, secrecy, money first, fake identity) into four lines of a case diary.

NEXT: MODULE 17

Privacy and Private Content Investigation

Victim dignity first - from FIR to content removal

Cyber Crime Investigator - Training Manual